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MAYDAY MIDAIR

A stabbing in the cockpit, a plane in a dive and a desperate passenger intervention – now investigators want to know how the attack was planned



Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu with Yaniv Hayun, who helped subdue the attacker with a chokehold

Gerry Shih, Lior Soroka
mirrorfeedback@timesofindia.com

JERUSALEM

The harrowing midair drama on Flight 1073 to Tel Aviv, as retold by passenger witnesses and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, sounded almost unbelievable: The co-pilot stabbed the captain in the cockpit, then tried to crash the plane before passengers subdued him and backup pilots landed safely in Saudi Arabia.

With passengers' lives spared and the hero pilot and alleged attacker hospitalised, investigators in Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Israel were trying to piece together Thursday how – in the post-9/11 era of tightened security – such an attack could have happened.

Major security lapses

Several lapses were already in focus. The co-pilot, whom Israeli officials have identified as an Omani national, should not have been allowed to fly to Tel Aviv under Israeli protocols that prohibit citizens from countries that do not have diplomatic ties with Israel from landing in Tel Aviv. Oman has not normalised relations with Israel.

It was also not clear how the co-pilot brought a weapon on board – or whether he did. Videos of the aftermath of Wednesday's attack, circulating online, showed the pilot bleeding, and passengers said he had been stabbed. While Saudi and Emirati investigators have yet to confirm many details from the incident, the initial accounts point to significant security breaches. Flights from Dubai to Tel Aviv have flourished in the five years since the UAE and Israel normalised relations in 2020, analysts say. Flydubai, owned by the Emirati government, alone flies 10 round trips a day.

On Wednesday, the airline suspended its flights to Israel.

Key questions

Investigators, meanwhile, zeroed in on the key questions.

"It's right now at the centre of the investigation of the joint team of Omani security services and Mossad: How is it possible for a guy of this nationality to fly the aircraft?" said Oded Ailam, a former head of counterterrorism at Mossad, the Israeli external intelligence agency. "One of the theories is that he had two passports, but that has to be answered to eliminate further incidents."

On Thursday, Israeli media reported that the suspect may have used an emergency axe that was already in the cockpit to carry out the attack.

Ailam said that whatever weapon had been found needed to be investigated but noted that

passengers, pilots and other aircraft crew typically undergo the same level of checks at airport security.

So far, Israeli officials have refrained from criticising potential screening failures, either in Flydubai's hiring process or at the terminal of Dubai International Airport.

Israel joins probe

In television interviews on Wednesday, Netanyahu highlighted the fact that up to 1 million Israelis have travelled to Dubai, and he praised the UAE and its carrier for keeping flights running even during the US-Israeli war against Iran.

Netanyahu said UAE President Mohamed bin Zayed al-Nahyan invited Israel to join the Emirati investigation once the suspect is transferred to the Emirates. The Omani suspect is being held and

interrogated by Saudi authorities.

T z v i k a Manes, who was sitting in the first row of business class with his family, recalled that his wife was waiting for the bathroom outside the cockpit when she screamed: "They're stabbing the pilot! They're stabbing the pilot!"

The cockpit door was open, apparently because the wounded Captain Smit Machchhar had managed to release it despite his injuries, said Manes, who is the head of underwriting at Israel's Bank Leumi.

Under normal conditions, the cockpit door on the plane, a Boeing

Passengers rescued from Flydubai flight that was at the centre of the attack at Ben Gurion International Airport near Tel Aviv, Israel on September 30



The suspect may have used an emergency axe kept in the cockpit to attack Captain Smit Machchhar, Israeli media reported

737 Max 8, uses a deadbolt that can be locked from the cockpit side, according to a 2025 Boeing manual for flight attendants.

Manes said his wife then alerted another pilot who was outside the cockpit and unaware of what was happening.

Yaniv Hayun, an Israeli plumber, also jumped into the fray, according to witness accounts, apparently placing the attacker in a chokehold.

"He snapped into action, and at that very second, the plane started to dive," Manes recalled. "The relief pilot and Yaniv Hayun overpowered the attacker, and the pilot stabilised the plane."

Thank God he didn't join family's textile business!

Captain Smit Machchhar, the Indian pilot who was stabbed in the cockpit of the Flydubai flight and is admitted to a hospital in Tabuk, Saudi Arabia, almost didn't become a pilot. His family is into the textile business and he flirted with the idea of signing up before the cockpit drew him in.

After Smit's heroic actions saved over 170 lives, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu described him as a "true hero."

"Despite being stabbed and seriously injured, he fought back, resisted, opened the cockpit door, and enabled passengers and crew to overpower the attacker," Netanyahu said on X. He said the other pilot – whose identity has not been disclosed – stabbed Machchhar and "apparently tried to crash

the aircraft with everyone on board".

Machchhar told a podcast in October 2025 that he originally planned to join his family's textile business before being bitten by the "aviation bug" while studying a management course. His mother was "scared" at the prospect of him flying, he said, though his father took it well and his family supported his decision. He spent about 18 months training in New Zealand in 2008 at Mainland Air, before returning to India to further his flying career.

Mainland Air chief executive Philip Kean told New Zealand's 1 News that Machchhar was a strong student and natural leader and that they have remained in contact in the years since.

Victoria Craw



Smit Machchhar

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THE FAMILY MAN

Neighbours, friends & relatives hail hero pilot Smit Machchhar as ambitious, jovial and with a deep devotion to his family

Gauri Deekonda
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Gentle, intelligent, calm, genuine, family-oriented – the words of praise that poured in from friends and family for Captain Smit Machchhar would never make you believe that this jovial, soft-spoken 39-year-old pilot from Ghatkopar would be hailed by world leaders and millions of Indians for his lion-hearted act that foiled a 9/11-style attack on a Flydubai flight on Wednesday.

But if there's one thing that everyone who knows him agrees on – it's his love for flying. "He has always lived for a life in the skies."

I have never really seen him doing anything outside aviation," said Akshay Doshi, family friend to the Machchhars, who lives next door to them in Swastik Heights CHG in Ghatkopar.

Doshi has known the Machchhar family since 2013 and said that they had moved into the building in 2012. "Smit is very friendly, jovial and family-oriented. He has two children and has always been a family man. Since our flats are adjacent, the doors were always open and we could walk into each other's homes anytime," he said.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 8

THANK GOD HE DIDN'T JOIN THE FAMILY BUSINESS! FACING PAGE



Captain Smit Machchhar

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PAGE THAT says there's no pleasing this city. Got air-rail connectivity, and you're still complaining

Sweet succession

ANYONE who knows this diarist knows of her love for Meher Pinto's little chocolate bombs. We've pressed the delicious truffles upon friends and converted colleagues who now carry boxes home as gifts. What we somehow didn't know? Pinto is grand-aunt to Nicole Marker, daughter of Lyla and Zubin Marker. Who knew that family tree came dipped in chocolate? Nicole returned from Los Angeles last year after a master's at USC and joined aunt Ghazala Pinto in the business Meher began at home in 1978. "I always knew I would work with them," she tells us. So now, three generations guard the recipes, while a long-serving all-women team makes fresh batches daily. Nicole brings the business nous and, lately, pistachio-kunafa truffles and chocolate barks. She also plans to widen the brand's reach. Which means the city may soon lose bragging rights.



Nicole Marker



@SridharanAnand So, Captain Smit is from Mumbai. I'm guessing he's a Sionist.

Home improvement

THERE was a time when Aslam Inamdar rode trains without a ticket to reach kabaddi tournaments and worked at tea stalls to keep his sporting ambitions alive. Now, the Asian Games gold medallist is setting up a kabaddi training club in Taklibhan, the Maharashtra village where he grew up. Clearly, the 26-year-old has covered considerable ground since those early scrambles, including captaining Puneri Paltan to its maiden Pro Kabaddi League title in 2024. But it is the distance between where he began and where he is now that seems to matter most. "I want young, underprivileged players to dream big and aim to achieve even more than I have," he tells your diarist. For a man who once couldn't afford the journey, that's quite a return ticket.



Aslam Inamdar

LIFE AT LARGE

Phani Tetali



"I just realised that I am better off being unemployed than being a tax paying employee!"

Material witnesses

ANYONE who was anyone seemed to find a reason to be in Kala Ghoda on Wednesday, where designer Amit Aggarwal was welcoming guests into his new space. Known for turning metallic polymers and unlikely materials into wonderfully sculptural clothes, Aggarwal had plenty of competition for the eye. Sushmita Sen, Tamannaah Bhatia and Manushi Chhillar were there, and your diarist also spotted Khushnaz Turner, Himani Rajiv Shah, Anshula Kapoor, Babil Khan, Divya and Amrita Thakur, Maia Sethna, Harmann Kaur and Rooshad Shroff among a crowd that cut neatly across the city's fashion, design and society circles. We love how Niket Deshpande took on this tricky windowless



Amit Aggarwal, Khushnaz Turner and Himani Rajiv Shah

heritage structure, with split levels and exposed girders, and made its peculiarities part of the design. With the clothes, the architecture and a guest list this good competing for attention, one hardly knew where to look.

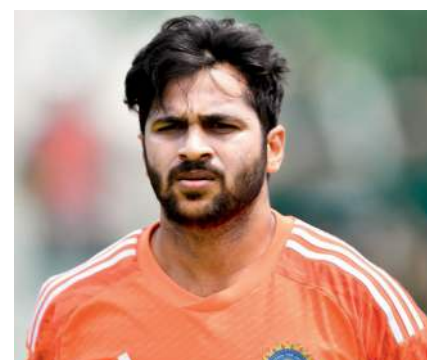
Black to the future

Wamiqa Gabbi makes a case for classic glamour but Rajkumar Rao keeps his side of the style bargain, too

A whole new ball game

YOUR diarist has had a peek at the team sheet for Mumbai's rather improbable cricket-meets-baseball date, and it has acquired considerably more muscle. Shardul Thakur, Jitesh Sharma and Kashvee Gautam are set to join Suryakumar 'Sky' Yadav on October 24, when the Mumbai Football Arena hosts India's first MLBx contest. Across the diamond will be some serious American hardware: World Series winners Nick Swisher and

Jonny Gomes, five-time All-Star Adrián González and 2015 Cy Young winner Jake Arrieta. The format is a brisk three-on-three affair, with cricketers and baseball greats divided across four sides, which should settle, or perhaps start, several arguments about who can really hit. Badshah and KR\$NA provide the soundtrack. Our eye, though, is on Thakur and Arrieta. Mumbai has seen plenty of crossover parties; few have required this much hand-eye coordination.



Shardul Thakur

Tailpiece

THERE'S greenwashing, and then there's halo management. An expert in both areas has been climbing beautifully, collecting important friends at home and useful ones in other capitals. The accompanying mythology is beautiful: purpose, generosity... all the words that make success sound well-deserved. Your diarist, however, hears a less heartwarming story from those powering the engine room. And never mind that, there is also livelier gossip travelling with this ambitious passport, about how enthusiastically certain doors have been opened after hours. Now, if pleasure and professional advancement happen to share a pillow, who are we to disturb the arrangement? We only wish some warmth would travel further down the food chain. For now, we're prepping for the awkward questions years from now, when everyone will presumably be astonished, as they always are. Funny how the glam set never quite knows whom it is getting into bed with.

Ample water still four years away for Mumbai

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Mumbai may have to wait at least four years for a substantial increase in its water supply, with major augmentation projects still some distance from completion. The city's daily demand is 4,662 million litres, against a normal supply of around 3,950 MLD. With the 10 per cent cut in place, current supply is about 3,650 MLD.

The BMC told the Standing Committee on Thursday that nearly 34 per cent of the city's water supply is lost to leakage, theft and other distribution losses. The civic body aims to reduce these losses by 10 per cent, which it estimates could add nearly 400 MLD to the supply.

The city's water requirement is estimated to reach around 5,132 MLD by 2030.

Gargai delayed, Manori pending

Work on the Gargai dam, which will supply 440 MLD, was supposed to begin in October 2026 but has now been pushed to January 2027. Once construction begins, the Rs 5,000-crore project is expected to take four years to complete.

The BMC has also begun surveying for the proposed desalination plant at Manori. The first phase will provide 200 MLD, while the second phase will provide

Mumbai's water demand is already 1,012 MLD higher than its current supply, with the city relying on a 10% cut and existing lake stocks until major projects such as Gargai and Manori come on stream

more than 200 MLD. The project is expected to take four years to complete.

Cut to conserve water stock

The BMC imposed a 10 per cent water cut in May 2026 to conserve the existing water stock until July 2027. The city's seven lakes hold 13.93 lakh million litres, or 96.31 per cent of their capacity, against an annual requirement of 14.47 lakh million litres.

Between January and August 2026, the BMC received 17,906 complaints about meter-related leakages and 4,090 about unauthorised connections. Of these, 3,802 were disconnected and 282 regularised. Since June 2022, 26,774 connections have been issued under 'Water for All'.

The BMC is also preparing an OTP-based tanker policy to prevent tankers serving establishments, including five-star hotels, from drawing directly from the municipal network. Operators would instead have to use authorised wells.

Recycled water in pipeline

The BMC is considering treating sewage water for potable use, although the proposal is yet to receive final approval and remains a long-term plan. Six sewage treatment plants are being developed and will treat around 2,400 MLD of sewage, with plans to supply around 1,200 MLD of recycled tertiary-treated water for civic and industrial reuse.

The Colaba Advanced Tertiary Treatment Plant has begun operations, while plants at Versova (180 MLD) and Ghatkopar (337 MLD) are targeted for completion by March 2027. The Dharavi (418 MLD) and Bandra (360 MLD) plants are slated for completion by late 2027, while the Malad plant (427 MLD) is scheduled to be ready by May 2028.

"We can use treated water as potable water, after treating it for potable use," said Additional Municipal Commissioner Abhijit Bangar. "The idea is to take this water to a potable water treatment plant and re-treat it with raw water and supply it to the city," he added.

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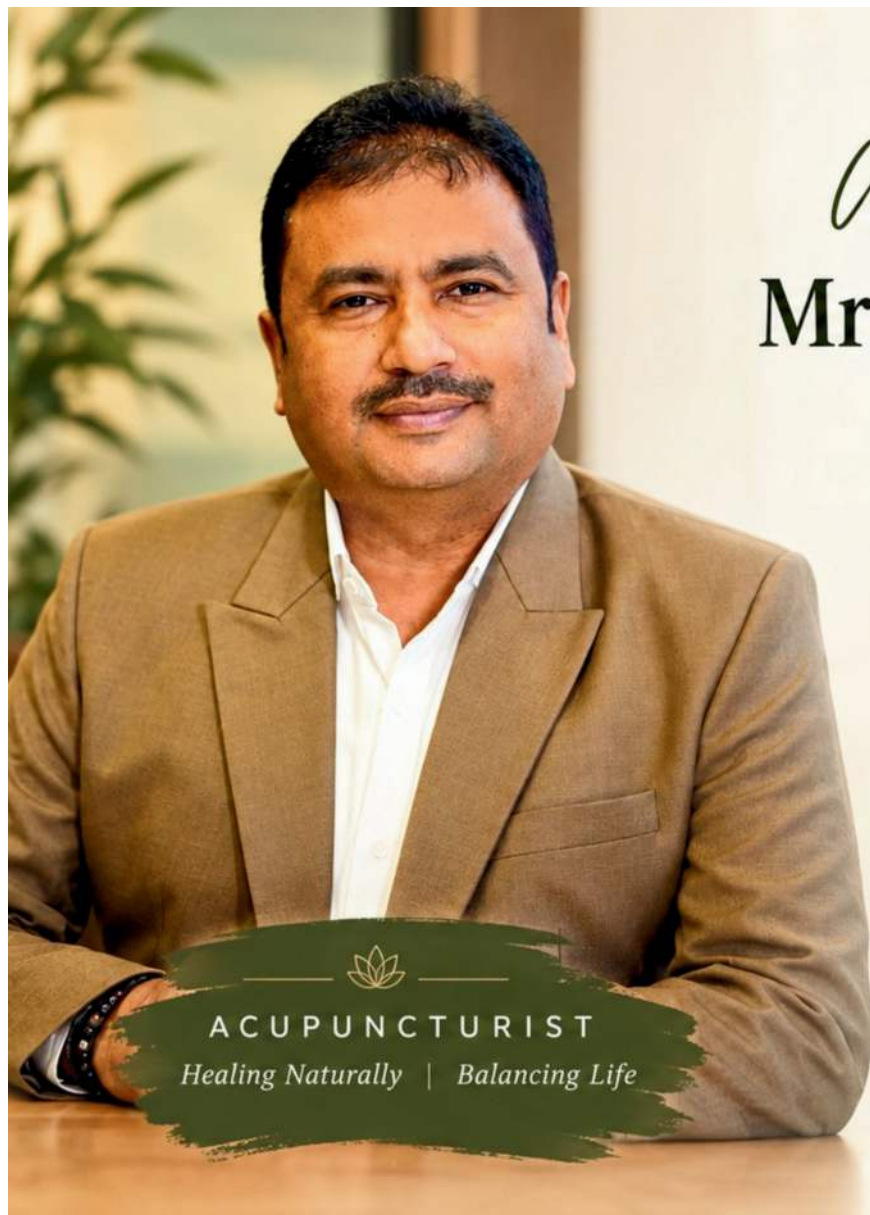
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Key to the missing body

PHOTOS: BY SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The case was solved by Senior PI Jabbar Tamboli (right) of LTT Railway Police Station, along with Constable Swapnil Shinde (left) and PC Damendra Hadge

A single Honda key found on an unidentified body helps GRP trace 19-yr-old after a two-month investigation and offer closure to his family

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A Honda motorcycle key found on an unidentified body has helped the Lokmanya Tilak Terminus (LTT) Government Railway Police (GRP) identify a 19-year-old man who had been missing for more than two months.

The body was found on the railway tracks between Chembur and Govandi on July 19, the same day Soham Pradhan, a resident of Kamraj Nagar, went missing. He had no wallet, documents or phone on him. Police found only two train tickets and the key among his belongings.

The GRP eventually traced the key to a motorcycle owned by Soham's uncle after contacting dealerships and checking the details of around 1,500 Honda motorcycle owners.

Sudden disappearance

Soham had travelled to Khandeshwar with his mother on the morning of July 19 to visit relatives. After returning home, he had a minor argument with her and left the house on his motorcycle, leaving his wallet, money and phone behind.

His parents, Sandipal Pradhan and his wife, initially believed he had gone out to meet friends and would return later. When he did not return by the following morning, they approached Pantnagar police station in Ghatkopar and registered a missing person report. Police examined CCTV footage from the area and found Soham riding towards an intersection. However, the trail ended soon afterwards as several cameras along the route were not functioning.

Body found on tracks

Meanwhile, the LTT GRP had registered an accidental death report after a man was found dead on the tracks between Chembur and Govandi. According to the train motorman, the man appeared to be lying across the tracks as the train approached, raising the possibility of suicide.

With no identification documents on the body, the GRP began looking for other clues. Two train tickets from Khandeshwar to Sewri were found, but the date and time stamps were smudged and could not be read. The only other significant clue was the motorcycle key.

GRP personnel examined CCTV footage from Khandeshwar towards Chembur and Sewri. However, gaps in the footage, particularly between 5pm and 6pm, prevented them from establishing the man's movements.

With the identity of the deceased still unknown, the GRP decided to trace the motorcycle associated with the key.

Officers checked parking areas outside Khandeshwar railway station and nearby roads, manually trying the key on Honda motorcycles parked in the area. After finding no match, they extended the search to the nearby highway and later to Chembur railway station, where they checked more motorcycles.

The search yielded no result.



With the identity of the deceased (Soham Pradhan, left) unknown, the GRP decided to trace the motorcycle associated with the key. They achieved a breakthrough after painstaking efforts



Senior Inspector Jabbar Tamboli of the LTT GRP then suggested another approach. The team contacted Honda

dealerships in Chembur, Sion and Ghatkopar and sought details of bikes sold since 2020.

After completing the legal formalities, the GRP obtained details of about 1,500 vehicle owners. Officers began contacting them to establish whether they had lost a motorcycle or had a family member who was missing.

Breakthrough after 600 calls

The breakthrough came on September 26, when officers had contacted around 600 people on the list. One of the calls was answered by the wife of a vehicle owner named Yadav, who was in Uttar Pradesh. She provided his Mumbai contact details. When contacted, Yadav confirmed that his motorcycle was with him. But he told officers that a family in his neighbourhood had been searching for their missing son for more than two months.

The team then called another person on the list, Jija Pradhan. He confirmed that he owned the Honda motorcycle and told officers that he had lent it to his 19-year-old nephew, Soham. He also said Soham had been missing along with the motorcycle since mid-July.

The GRP asked Soham's family to come to the LTT station with identification documents. His parents arrived within an hour.

By then, the body had already been disposed of by the local authorities in accordance with regulations governing the preservation of unidentified bodies in mortuaries. The family, however, formally identified Soham through photographs, a description of his clothes and official documents.

Senior Inspector Tamboli said the investigation had been challenging because the team had very few clues.

"The case took two months with minimal details available to us – just a single key," he said. "We had to uncover both the identity and the circumstances surrounding his death within a limited window. With just one key, our team uncovered the truth and gave a grieving family the answers they deserved."

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Thane rehab: Info chief pulls up TMC

Information Commission directs police to serve summons after municipal engineer fails to furnish records on Vartak Nagar redevelopment

N Ganesh
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The State Information Commission has summoned a Thane Municipal Corporation (TMC) officer to appear before it for an enquiry after he allegedly failed to provide information as directed and did not appear for a subsequent hearing.

State Information Commissioner Shekar Channe of the Konkan division was peeved that executive engineer Sandeep Sawant did not provide the information ordered by the commission on June 15 and also failed to appear before it during the subsequent proceeding.

The matter relates to 127 families from Vartak Nagar who claim they were rendered homeless after the redevelopment of buildings where they had lived for several decades. The residents allege that they were deprived of their homes due to the "connivance of TMC and MHADA".

Channe has directed the Thane police commissioner's office and the senior inspector of Vartak Nagar police station to serve the summons on Sawant.

The summons has been issued under Section 18(3)(c) of the RTI Act, 2005. Sawant is an executive engineer with the Lokmanya Nagar/Savarkar Nagar ward.

The RTI appeal arose from an application filed by Salil Rane with the TMC regarding the redevelopment of MHADA buildings 54, 55 and 56 at Vartak Nagar. Rane had sought copies of all communications from 1970 related to the procurement of the buildings from MHADA as service quarters.

The query was based on a claim made by the TMC before the high court that the three buildings had been procured from MHADA as service quarters.

When contacted, Sawant said he had not received the summons.

"The reason they are unable to provide the communication regarding the procurement of the three MHADA buildings as service quarters is because it doesn't exist.

"TMC is weaving a story that these were service quarters and yet it is not denying that there were residents who were not civic employees living in these buildings," said Sudhir Parab, one of the residents fighting for their homes.

Mirror had reported on March 17, that residents of the three buildings were housed there after being uprooted during a road widening project undertaken in the 1970s. The civic body at the time allotted tenements in the three buildings to project-affected persons (PAPs) as well as civic employees.

However, during the redevelopment process, TMC conveyed to MHADA that the buildings were occupied only by civic staff. MHADA, which owns the land, subsequently gave its approval accordingly.

Under the conditions laid down by MHADA for redevelopment of the

service quarters, the erstwhile PAPs were allotted rooms which they could neither sell nor rent out.

The High Court, too, in its order, observed that occupants of the MHADA buildings who had approached the court were yet to be rehabilitated.



BY SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Vartak Nagar residents await rehabilitation amid a dispute over the buildings' status



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No trace of Saki Naka drain death probe

Three months after a 60-yr-old man drowned in an uncovered drain, an RTI query finds no inquiry or action

Faizan Khan
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Three months after a 60-year-old daily wage worker fell into an uncovered storm-water drain on Khairani Road in Saki Naka, questions over accountability are unanswered, with an RTI revealing that the BMC's Vigilance Department has no records of any inquiry, suspension, penalty or blacklisting linked to his death. On July 2, Aslam Isak Shaikh fell into an uncovered storm-water drain on flooded Khairani Road while speaking on his phone. His body was recovered after 1.5 hours, triggering public outrage and promises of an inquiry, official suspensions and contractor blacklisting.

However, an RTI application filed

BY SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Shakeel Ahmed RTI activist

WHAT THE RTI SOUGHT

- Inquiry report and certified records
- Details of inquiry officer/committee
- Names of those held responsible
- Suspension orders of officials
- Action against contractor, including blacklisting
- Details of departmental or criminal proceedings
- Compensation paid to victim's family
- Safety measures and orders issued after the incident

by activist Shakeel Ahmed Shaikh has raised questions over the probe. According to RTI response, the application seeking details of the inquiry and action taken was transferred between BMC offices over 28 days before reaching the Vigilance Department.

The department informed the

applicant that no records were available for any of the eight queries.

Bureaucratic shuffle

Shaikh filed the RTI on September 1, seeking the inquiry report, details of suspended officials, contractor blacklisting and compensation.

The application was transferred on

September 2 under Section 6(3) of the RTI Act to the Deputy Municipal Commissioner (General Administration). After eight days, it was sent to the Chief Officer (Inquiry) on September 10, the office said the matter fell under its jurisdiction.

It was then forwarded to the Deputy Chief Officer (Inquiry), Zone 5, on September 11, and transferred to the Chief Engineer (Vigilance) at Ghatkopar on September 23. On September 28, the Assistant Engineer (Vigilance, L Ward) responded, stating that no records were available for the eight queries.

"Since the DMC, Chief Enquiry Officer, Deputy Chief Officer (Enquiry), Chief Engineer (Vigilance) and other departments are part of the same BMC structure, treating them as separate 'Public Authorities' and

invoking Section 6(3) raises serious legal questions," Shaikh said.

He said the Public information officer (PIO) can seek assistance under Section 5(4) if records are held by another BMC department, instead of repeatedly transferring the application.

"When the tragedy occurred, civic authorities promised strict action and claimed a vigilance probe was initiated. Yet, when we ask the Chief Engineer (Vigilance) for proof, they say nothing exists on their records. Where did the inquiry go? Was there ever one?" Shaikh added. He has filed a First Appeal before the Additional Municipal Commissioner (Western), challenging the transfer. The BMC has informed him that he can also appeal to the Executive Engineer (Vigilance) within 30 days.

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How is Parth Pawar not responsible: HC

MUNDHWA LAND DEAL: Court asks why 99% stakeholder Parth was not made an accused while 1% stakeholder Patil was; grants Suryakant Yewale anticipatory bail

Krishna Shukla
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The Bombay High Court on Thursday questioned the police investigation into the Mundhwa land deal over the decision to make a 1 per cent stakeholder in the buyer company an accused while leaving its 99 per cent stakeholder out of the case.

Justice Madhav Jamdar questioned whether Parth Pawar, who holds a 99 per cent stake in Amadea Enterprises LLP, could be considered not to have benefited from a transaction involving the firm.

The observations came while the court granted anticipatory bail to suspended Pune City Tehsildar Suryakant Yewale, who is accused of misusing his official position in the transaction involving around 40 acres of land at Mundhwa, Pune. Yewale has denied the allegations and claimed he was falsely implicated.

Digvijay Patil, who holds a 1 per cent stake in Amadea Enterprises LLP, has been made an accused. The court questioned the investigating officer's position that Pawar was not responsible for the transaction.

Court questions police probe

The issue had first come up before the High Court on September 7, when it sought an explanation from the Director General of Police (DGP) and the investigating officer on why Pawar had not been named as an accused. The court also recorded an unattributed submission that Pawar had not been named because he was "very highly influential" and subsequently sought a personal affidavit from the DGP.

After examining the investigation papers, the DGP informed the High Court that there was a need for a "more professional and detailed investigation"



Rajya Sabha MP Parth Pawar

and directed Pune Police Commissioner Amitesh Kumar to conduct further investigation. He also said he would monitor the probe.

The state had opposed the plea, arguing that custodial interrogation was necessary given the seriousness of the allegations.

The land deal

The land was classified as Mahar Watan land, was in government possession and had been leased to the Botanical Survey of India (BSI), according to the FIR and court proceedings. It was subsequently sold to Amadea Enterprises LLP for about Rs 300 crore. The prosecution alleges that the transaction was carried out without the mandatory approval of the state government.

The deal suffered a setback in civil proceedings when, on July 3, a Pune civil court declared the sale deed in favour of Amadea Enterprises LLP "void ab initio, inoperative since the beginning and of no legal effect" and directed cancellation of the registration entries.

The criminal investigation continues into how the government land transaction was processed and the role of those allegedly involved.

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All it takes is a second

Dubai-based syndicate is using an exclusive app to split stolen money and route it through 7,000 bank accounts before converting it into cryptocurrency

Anish Patil
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A Dubai-based cyber fraud syndicate is allegedly using an exclusive mobile application called 'Banker Panel' to scatter money stolen from victims across thousands of bank accounts within seconds. Investigators found that the app was developed by the syndicate's alleged mastermind.

The modus operandi was simple but swift. Once fraud proceeds landed in an account controlled by the syndicate, 'Banker Panel' allegedly split the money into smaller amounts and transferred them to multiple accounts within a second. Police suspect the syndicate used around 7,000 accounts to move the proceeds, making it difficult to trace and freeze the money before it was moved again.

Crime Branch Unit 2 has so far

traced Rs 120 crore in cyber fraud proceeds transferred through various accounts.

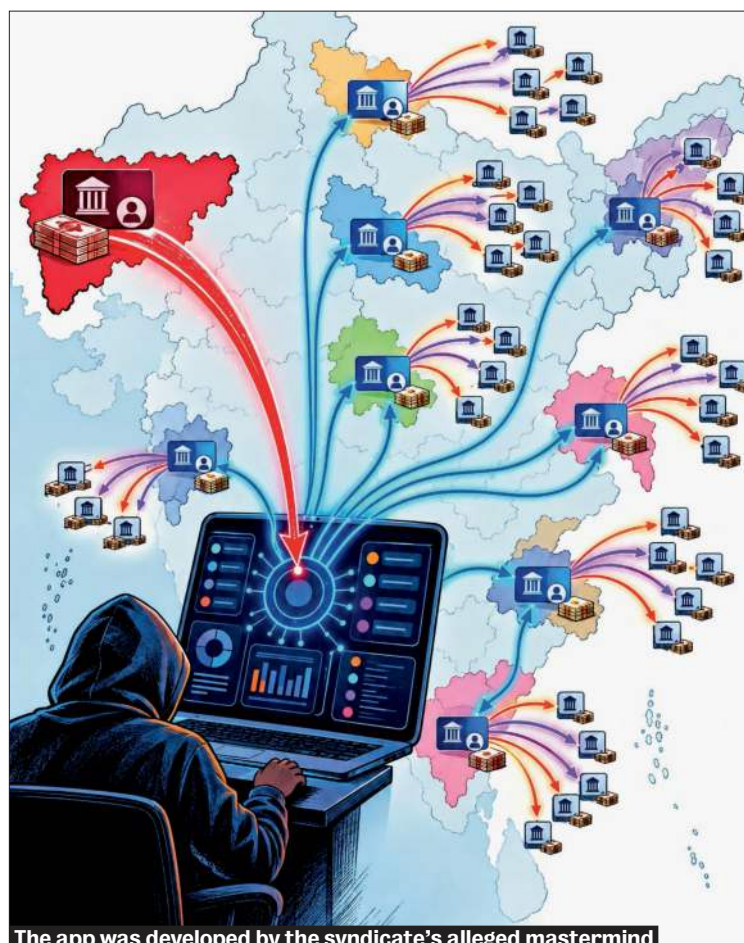
The amount is expected to rise as investigators identify more transactions linked to the syndicate. The probe has led to 21 arrests, including 12 alleged operatives picked up from a rented villa in Goa.

A second to scatter the loot

The alleged speed of the transfers gives the syndicate a crucial advantage. By the time a victim realised the fraud and approached the police or a bank, the money could already have passed through several accounts.

Police clarified that the approximately 7,000 accounts identified so far cannot all be categorised as mule accounts. Investigators are examining the role of each account and the layers through which the money was routed.

The operatives allegedly under-



The app was developed by the syndicate's alleged mastermind

went 15 days of training to use the application, process transactions and shift funds across accounts. The Goa villa allegedly served as an operations centre, where operators used laptops and mobile phones to monitor

incoming funds and move the money.

During the raid, officers seized 15 laptops, 85 mobile phones, 128 ATM cards, 76 SIM cards, 22 cheque books and 77 passbooks.

The operation emerged during the investigation of a cyber-related case registered at Paydhuni police station. Investigators suspect a separate network supplied bank accounts, activated SIM cards and banking kits, allowing the Goa-based operatives to control accounts opened in different names.

The speed of transfers gives the syndicate a big advantage. By the time a victim realised the fraud and approached the cops, the money could have passed through several accounts

Police are examining links between the transaction chain and cybercrime complaints from across the country, including digital arrest scams and malicious APK frauds.

Following the crypto trail
Investigators suspect the proceeds were eventually converted into Tether, or USDT, enabling overseas handlers, including those in Dubai, to access the funds. Police are examining the cryptocurrency channels and wallets allegedly used in the process.

The next challenge is to establish who controlled each stage – the accounts receiving victims' money, 'Banker Panel' distributing it, and the cryptocurrency wallets through which the proceeds allegedly reached overseas handlers.

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A CAPTAIN AND A GENTLEMAN

BY SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Doshi added that Smit had started an aviation academy in Mumbai a few years back. While he moved to Dubai in 2022, his parents Upendra and Geeta still live in Swastik Heights. His father is also involved in managing the academy, according to family friends and neighbours. Till 2022, Doshi would meet Smit Doshi at society functions, gatherings and festivals.

'He takes good care of his parents'

Much like Manoj Bajpayee's character in the hit OTT series The Family Man, Smit is known to balance the high-pressure demands of his profession with a quiet, unwavering devotion to his own family. Those who know him say he's deeply grounded by his love for his wife, Sonal, and their two children — a nine-year-old daughter and a son who will turn two.

Despite shifting base to Dubai, he kept coming back to Mumbai to meet his parents, neighbours said. Vipul Majithia, who lives in the building, said that Smit was a workaholic and understood the demanding nature of a pilot's profession. "Despite his busy schedule, whenever he got free time, he would come down to meet his parents, even if it was just for 24 or 48 hours. He takes a lot of care of his parents and is very devoted to them. Whenever he got the time, he would speak to his father. He is a thorough gentleman," he said.



Smit's father Upendra Machchhar

His paternal aunt, Neeta Machchhar, remembers him as a calm and academically bright child. "He was very good at studying, very calm, and very intelligent. He has always been a very lovely child of ours. The last time I spoke to him was on his wife Sonal's birthday," she said. Smit's uncle Kishorebhai confirmed that he was "much better now" and was recovering.

Another family friend, Rashmi Jayesh Modi, spoke about how his son Nirvik is "best friends" with Smit and had spoken to the pilot's wife following the incident. "We're praying for his quick recovery," she added.

'Uncle I'll take you flying when I get the chance'

Sixth-floor neighbour Bhikam M Ganna said he has known Smit for around 15-16 years and has watched

him grow up. "He has always been a genuine person, and he always wanted to become a pilot," he said. Ganna said Smit's father, Upendrabhai, was an active member of the building committee and currently serves as its treasurer. He recalled that Smit would return from Dubai for society functions and festivals. "We used to joke with Smit that whenever he became a captain, he should take us along on a flight, and he would say, 'Uncle, whenever I get a chance, I will take you.'"

Ashok Makwana, chairman of the building, said he has known Smit for around 30 years and his father for nearly 40 years. "His family is very good, and Smit himself has always been very helpful," he said.

Makwana said the families had known each other since their days in Ghatkopar and that Smit's parents continued to be part of their evening gatherings. "What he has done is truly wonderful. Not fearing for own life and saving the lives of around 180 people is a huge achievement. We only pray to God that he recovers quickly and comes back home," he said.

'He was active and playful in school'

Machchhar initially studied at MD



Smit with his wife Sonal, with whom he has two children

Bhatia School in Ghatkopar and later attended Gurukul Technology School in Ghatkopar from around Class 8 to 10. Parag Shah, the chairman of MD Bhatia School, said he has known Smit as a junior from his school days. "Coincidentally, we were both in the same school, though he was my junior. Today, I am the chairman of the school, and I feel very happy that a boy from our

school is now a global hero," he said. Yogita Parmar, principal of the school, said the institution was proud of its former student.

Shah confirmed that he had spoken to Smit's uncle and that the braveheart was out of danger. "His surgery is over. His parents, wife, cousin and brother are all in Dubai right now," he said.

Unnati R Padalia, academic head at Gurukul School, said the institution felt honoured to have Smit as one of its alumni. "He studied here from Class 8 to Class 10 and was an alumnus of the 2003 batch. He was an active and playful student who participated in various activities," she added.

Dr Vilas Shinde, Registrar of Welingkar Institute of Management Development & Research (WE School), said Smit studied at the institute in 2007-08. "He completed his PGDM, a one-year diploma in Business Administration, through the distance-learning mode from our institute," he said.



"Smit has always lived for a life in the skies. I have never really seen him doing anything outside aviation. He is very friendly, jovial and family-oriented. He has two children and has always been a family man"

—Akshay Doshi, neighbour and family friend



Residents of Swastik Heights, where the Machchhars live, hail the mohalla boy for his bravery in the sky

WILL THEY OR WON'T THEY?

Many NEET detainees ready for round two at CJP's Shivaji Park protest today; others to miss it as they will be 'busy'

Diwakar Sharma and
Anamika Gharat
mirrorfeedback@timesofindia.com

A few months after being detained and booked during CJP-linked protests in July, several protesters are preparing to return to the streets. Activists who faced police action during the NEET-related demonstrations are now set to join the Cockroach Janata Party's October 2 protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar at Shivaji Park.

The mobilisation comes after Mumbai Police detained and booked hundreds of protesters during the CJP-linked demonstrations in July. Around 400 people were booked in multiple cases during the protests.

Several of those who faced police action then are expected to join Friday's gathering, saying their earlier experience has not deterred them from exercising what they describe as their democratic right to protest. They have also urged the police against what they described as high-handed action, including detentions, and being bundled into police vans.

The October 2 protest has now been announced as a 'Jail Bharo Andolan' after police reportedly denied permission for the proposed gathering at Shivaji Park.

The July cases had also triggered legal support, with lawyers offering pro-bono assistance. The activists said the cases were subsequently scrapped.

Advocate Samya Korde, who was detained by a Mumbai Police team at her Pratiksha Nagar home during the July protests, said she would join Friday's gathering.

"This is very important for all of us to join the protest," Korde said, adding that several students and Left-wing activists had already protested at Azad Maidan on October 1.

Marol-based social activist Salim



Several protesters who participated in the NEET demonstrations in July were detained by cops; (right) CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke

Saboowala, who was detained during the July protests, said he was prepared to return despite the earlier police action.

"We were detained for exercising a democratic right. If peaceful protest becomes a reason for preventive detention, then what happens to the right to dissent? We will not be intimidated into silence. I am going to Shivaji Park to join the protest," he said.

Another activist, Feroze Mithiborewala, also said he was prepared to face detention again. "Last time, police vans were used to stop us from raising our voices. This time too, we are prepared to face detention, but we will not surrender our democratic

right to protest peacefully. I am joining the protest for a social cause. My friend Tushar Gandhi is also coming," he said. For some, however, the decision to return is less straightforward. Trisha Gupta, 22, who was booked in the earlier CJP case, said she was considering attending but was weighing the decision against her work commitments and the possible consequences of being booked again. "I am considering going for the protest this time. I was booked in the earlier CJP case, so I am aware of what can follow when you participate in a protest. Still, I feel that I should be



able to decide whether I want to participate this time," she said. Student Bhairavi Jagtap said she wanted to attend but was staying away after her parents urged her not to go, recalling the stress the family faced after she was booked during the earlier protest.

"I am honestly confused because many of my friends are planning to attend, and I would also like to go, but I cannot ignore what my family went through last time," she said.

Some activists will also miss Friday's protest because of prior engagements. Santacruz-based activist Sandhya Panaskar, who was detained and kept at Worli police station along with her preteen son during the July protests, said she had a cultural event on a social issue scheduled for the same day.

"I wanted to join the protest but if I am detained, my event will be hampered. So, I am not joining the protest on Friday," Panaskar said.

Model Rhiya Ahir, who became a face of the July protests after showing her palm to a Mumbai Police van in Dadar, said she would instead attend a 'Walk for Women' event demanding safer public spaces and an end to gender-based violence.

Goregaon-based activist Alex D'Souza, who was detained at a railway station while travelling to the July protest, said he had another commitment at a gathering in Mira Road. He was unsure if he would make it to Shivaji Park but said he would extend his support to CJP.

The girl who went to Supreme Court against bullying

Yadavi Rasiwasiya, bullied for nearly 11 years, seeks a law against bullying and ragging in schools and pre-university

Anamika Gharat
anamika.gharat@timesofindia.com

A 16-year-old Mumbai schoolgirl recently approached the Supreme Court seeking a comprehensive legal framework to prevent bullying in schools and ensure that complaints by students are properly addressed.

Yadavi Aditya Rasiwasiya, who says she was bullied for nearly 11 years of her school life, sought a law covering bullying and ragging in schools and pre-university institutions, along with mandatory mechanisms for schools to receive complaints, protect students, provide counselling and take appropriate action.

She also sought the inclusion of bullying and ragging awareness in school curricula.

When Yadavi's matter came up on September 29, the Supreme Court

referred to those earlier directions and directed that her grievances be forwarded to the concerned authorities as a representation for appropriate action in accordance with law.

"I was bullied for 11 years of my school life. I got through it, but what if someone else didn't? That thought constantly crossed my mind," Yadavi told Mumbai Mirror on Thursday, explaining what prompted her to take up the issue.

Yadavi said she began researching the existing legal and policy framework and found that there was no uniform law specifically protecting schoolchildren from bullying across India. "There is a policy in the CBSE board but nothing that covers all school-going children across India," she said.

She said while there are laws dealing with the safety of minors and a separate anti-ragging framework for college students, schoolchildren do



Petitioner Yadavi Rasiwasiya

not have similar comprehensive statutory protection against bullying. She also referred to laws addressing bullying in several Commonwealth coun-

tries. "The only way was to stand up for this menace, which I did by requesting the Supreme Court of India to form laws through a PIL," she said.

Her father, businessman Aditya Rasiwasiya, said he had come across several instances of children being bullied over things beyond their control. In one case, he recalled, a boy was repeatedly bullied by classmates because of his unusual surname, prompting his parents to eventually change the family surname.

According to Aditya, such incidents often remain isolated cases, with no uniform system requiring schools to follow a standard procedure when a child complains of bullying.

The issue became personal when Yadavi began facing problems at her own school. Aditya said the situation became difficult for her and the family eventually decided to change her

school. They then gave her time to recover and regain her confidence before pursuing the wider issue.

After settling into her new school and regaining confidence, Yadavi and her family decided to approach the Supreme Court. She eventually appeared virtually during the proceedings.

The Supreme Court has already recognised the importance of protecting students' mental health. In its 2025 judgment in Sukdeb Saha v State of Andhra Pradesh, the court issued directions concerning mental-health support and safety mechanisms in educational institutions, including measures to address bullying and ragging.

"I am thankful to the judiciary and proud that they heard a minor's plea and passed relevant orders," Yadavi said. She also thanked the lawyers who supported her and "saw merit" in her plea.

MUMBAICORE

THE PACE OF THE CHASE IN A LIMINAL SPACE

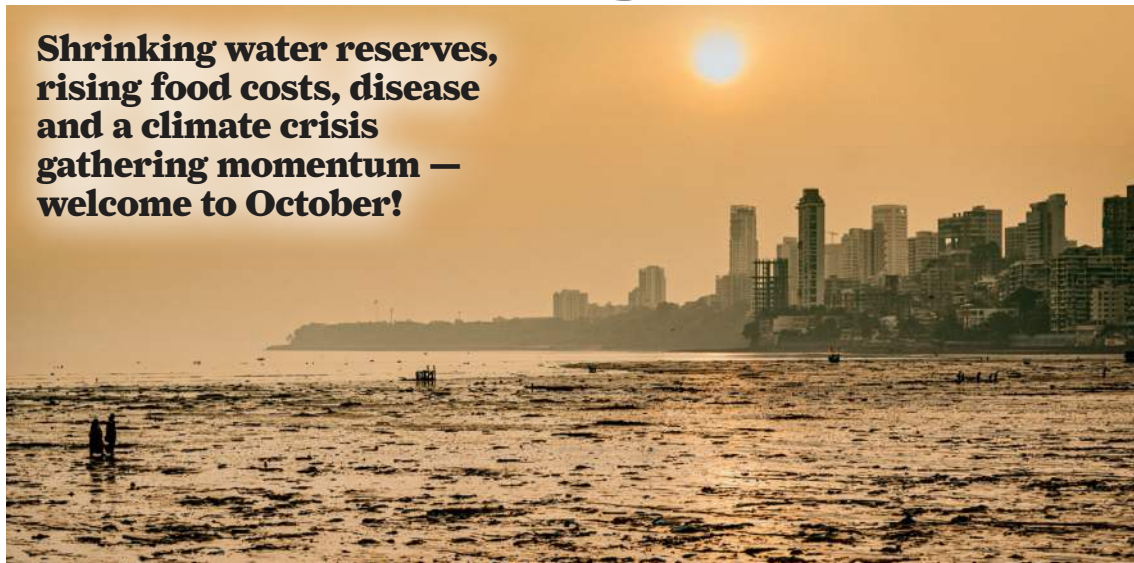


Genesia Alves

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The coming horrors

Shrinking water reserves, rising food costs, disease and a climate crisis gathering momentum — welcome to October!



Mumbai's 'second summer' is so terrifying it may require its own moniker

In Mumbai, the Beatles' 'Here Comes the Sun' is the soundtrack to October's impending horror. It may be Halloween month for folks abroad and our local Cultural Appropriaterati, but apart from the chances of being forced to imbibe foods haunted by the weird Pumpkin Spice (aka Lal-Bhopla-Masala), Mumbai's October is much scarier. In fact, our 'second summer' is so terrifying it may require its own moniker.

We could call it Shalloween in honour of our wells and lakes.

Mumbai was living on vapours before the delayed onset of the monsoon. Under 'normal' condi-

tions we face a shortfall of about 500 million litres of water a day. The Godzilla El Niño has caused an 18 per cent rainfall deficit. The BMC has tolled the bell — we have about 340 days of water, and will run out by May 2027. It could be quicker though. On Wednesday, Modak Sagar's levels fell by 21 metres in a single day! As the monsoon retreats, dams are at 75.5 per cent of capacity (last year they held 88 per cent). So far, the 10 per cent water cut remains even as officials are instructed to restrict construction and avoid 'thirsty' work like making cement roads. Not scared yet?

We could call it Falloween in honour of the agricultural distress and our cost-of-living crisis.

So what if the soybean crop failed? We can bolster our protein intake with imported tempeh. Except, dwindling soybean supplies raise the spectre of higher prices across most essentials, especially dairy and poultry. Food shortages don't manifest as empty shelves and fisticuffs in the aisles. They slowly creep under your door and leach affordability of ingredients, cooking gas and electricity. You'll hear the howling in your empty wallet, but that's not as terrifying as

what's happening where drought has been declared. Farmworkers are forced into distress migration, often arriving in cities to look for work. But Mumbai is barely a solution. Cost of living comparisons suggest that it is cheaper to live in Delhi (by 45 per cent) or Bangalore (by 25 per cent). Housing, of course, is the Vampire in Chief; some estimates suggest a 1-BHK will bleed you by about 28K in Bangalore, 22K in Delhi and 65K in Mumbai.

We could call it Salloween. That wan, low-energy zombie vibe in October? Don't blame yourself. This year's monsoon saw instances of malaria rise by nearly 12 per cent compared to last year. We also had hauntings by the norovirus and rotavirus. Dengue cases increased by 28 per cent courtesy warmer, more humid weather and lots and lots of yummy stagnant water. It gets worse. A very high percentage of us are Vitamin D deficient because sure, we have more sun than we need, but pollution scatters UVB rays. Result? We don't make enough Vitamin D. Body composition tests run across Indian cities show that even for those who strength train, their Skeletal Muscle Mass doesn't improve, or worse, slides backward. Hair-raising yes, because the deficiency can also cause hair loss.

Gallows-ween is a contender only because of how many people will die from climate change. India will see nearly 16,000 additional deaths caused by heat between now and February 2027. Even more horrifying, a recent study by Princeton University and the University of Chicago analysed city-specific climate change hazards and well, loss

of human life in Mumbai will occur at almost 10 times higher than official statistics predict.

But truly, maybe it should be called Calloween because our responses so far have been naive, ill-prepared and immature.

A week in July saw 898 millimetres of rainfall. With no other recourse, BMC's pumping stations drained 42,900 million litres of water into the sea. That's 10 extra days of water we'd need next May. The directive "wash your car with borewell water" displays an unsettling priority for cars to be shiny as they drive on heat-generating roads that repel aquifer recharge.

Johannesburg, years into its water crisis, had 10,000 private boreholes drilled in the last decade. As climate change pushes the middle class into poverty, taps remain dry. But one wealthy citizen admitted her private borewell kept her pool full and her lawn green even as she shed a tear for the less privileged.

Has no one watched the classic horror 'Soylent Green' about worldwide failures of the food systems? Have we forgotten how it felt watching 'Contagion' at the start of the pandemic and worrying about the social implications of maintaining a healthy population? Why isn't cancelling holidays to Nepal, Thailand, Spain, or New York because of climate change scaring us off the impending months of festivities *cough* consumption. Or maybe they want us to believe that the way to deal with the October heat is to have your blood run cold.

Genesia Alves is a journalist and Mumbai is her ancestral village.

LAUGHINGSUTRAS

THE NOT-SO-INNER-VOICE OF A COMMON MUMBAIKAR



Shiv Shambale

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AI will kill us all by 2030? Beta, get in line

A researcher at one of the world's biggest AI firms quit recently with a note saying the technology could kill all of humanity by 2030. His colleague, the man in charge of making these machines behave, agreed: "We really do earnestly believe AI could kill all humans!"

Note the exclamation mark. Not a full stop. An exclamation mark — the punctuation we keep for weddings and cricket.

The news reached our building WhatsApp group at 6.42 am. By 6.44 it was followed by a rose-with-good-morning GIF. By 6.51 the group had moved on to whether the water tank cleaning is this Sunday or next.

In any other city, the end of the world gets a candlelight vigil. Here, it got two minutes and lost to a parking dispute.

Besides, 2030 is a crowded year. Our society redevelopment is due in 2030. The new Metro line is 2030. The road outside was dug up in

March and the contractor has committed to 2030. If the machines want that slot, they must submit three quotations and wait for the society's NOC.

Promptly, the boss of Nvidia, whose chips this entire party runs on, declared there is "zero chance" AI ends the world by 2030. Not "unlikely". Zero. Beta, when the cement supplier certifies the building, you check the pillars.

Meanwhile, the very company whose people raised the alarm is reportedly weighing a new model before its stock market listing. Every Mumbai builder understands. The structure may have questions, but the sample flat must open before the launch.

The worry is recursive self-improvement. Today's AI helps

build tomorrow's AI, which builds the one after that. More than 80 per cent of the code at that company is now written by its own AI.

This is the tuition-class model. First you teach the boy. Then the boy teaches the batch. Then the boy opens his own class opposite yours, drops the fees by Rs 200, and



your students are gone by June.

Everyone's answer is a kill switch. But as one news report pointed out, switching off an AI is not like switching off one machine; it lives inside a web of connected services and passwords. Our building also has a main switch. It is in the meter room, the key is with the secretary, and the secretary is in Lonavala.

Nor will anyone slow down. America and

China will keep racing because each fears the other won't stop. This is society parking. Everybody agrees there are too many cars. Nobody sells his car first.

Aaji, who has outlived four ends of the world, Y2K, and a secretary who promised the lift by Diwali, put down her knitting.

"Every generation gets one apocalypse," she said. "Ours was the atom bomb. Yours is a computer that talks. At least yours says sorry."

The nephew was more practical. "If the world ends in 2030, my education loan also ends, no?"

So no, I will not tell you to panic. This city does not do panic; it adjusts. Usually, the builder says everything is fine and you discover the seepage yourself, in June. Here, the people building the thing are the ones saying they are not sure they can control it. And our IT minister says that safeguards must be built into the models by those who make them. Correct. The builder fixes the crack, not the tenant.

When the builder himself points at the crack, you do not need to run out of the building. You just need to stop pretending it is a shadow.

Readers may please write to me at shiv.shambale@timesofindia.com and tell me what else has been promised to you by 2030. Bonus marks if it involves a lift, a builder, or a road dug up during a previous apocalypse.



ASK THE SEXPERT

Dr Tanaya Narendra, aka Dr Cuterus, is an Oxford-trained doctor, bestselling author and one of the country's most trusted voices on sexual and reproductive health

1 I am a 42-year-old man. I had a vasectomy years ago but now notice pain after ejaculation. Could the operation be responsible?

A small proportion of men develop persistent or intermittent testicular or scrotal pain after vasectomy, sometimes called post vasectomy pain syndrome, and discomfort can occasionally worsen with ejaculation. But infections, prostate/pelvic floor problems and other causes can produce similar symptoms. As yours is new, see a urologist because an examination can determine where the pain originates and guide treatment.

2 I am a 26-year-old woman. I am a lesbian, and penetration with fingers or toys causes pain. What medical conditions should be ruled out?

I'm sorry to hear that sex hurts. Depending on where the pain occurs, possibilities include pelvic floor overactivity, vaginismus (or what we call genitopelvic pain penetration disorder), vestibulodynia/vulvodynia, as well as infections, skin conditions, and endometriosis. A gynaecologist or sexual medicine physician can examine you, and pelvic floor physiotherapy can be transformative when muscle tension is involved. Meanwhile, use plenty of water or silicone-based lubricant and don't repeatedly push through pain.

SEND YOUR QUERIES TO Ask the Sexpert, Mumbai Mirror, Times Of India Building, Dr D N Road, Mumbai 400001 or email at sexpert@timesofindia.com

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WIKIMEDIA COMMONS



Mahatma Gandhi covered roughly 390km on foot during the 1930 Dandi March

WALK THIS WAY

On Gandhi Jayanti, orthopaedic surgeon Dr Pradeep Moonot shares what modern medicine has learnt about the remarkable mechanics of our feet, and whether spending some time out of shoes can make them stronger

Today, photographs of Mahatma Gandhi walking during the freedom struggle are likely to offer a familiar reminder of how much of his life was spent on foot. He was 60 when he set out on the Dandi March in 1930, covering roughly 390km over 24 days. His simple footwear also provides an opportunity to examine a question that continues to interest researchers in biomechanics and sports medicine: what happens to our feet when they spend most of their waking hours inside shoes?

The human foot contains 26 bones, 33 joints and a complex arrangement of muscles, tendons and ligaments. Some of its smallest muscles, known as the intrinsic foot muscles, begin and end within the foot itself. They help support the arch, stabilise the toes and control the foot as our weight moves from heel to forefoot with every step.

Shoes change the way the foot interacts with the ground, but that does not make shoes harmful. They protect us from heat, sharp objects and injury, while appropriate cushioning and support can be valuable for people with particular foot conditions. The more interesting question is whether feet, like other parts of the body, benefit from occasionally being allowed to work a little harder.

Research suggests they may. Studies of exercises targeting the intrinsic foot muscles have found improvements in foot strength, while some research into minimalist footwear suggests that it may strengthen certain muscles of the foot and toes. The evidence is still developing, however, and does not support the claim that everyone should abandon conventional footwear.

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Check your shoes for wear and tear

Start with fit. When you stand, your toes should have enough room to spread rather than being compressed together. A shoe that repeatedly produces redness, blisters or calluses at the same points deserves attention, particularly if it is causing pain.

Look at an old pair that you wear frequently. Some wear on the sole is inevitable and does not, by itself, reveal whether you walk "correctly".

Also check if there is uneven wear of the heel or the sole area. This may indicate you may have either flat foot or a high arch foot. Any striking differences between the two shoes, particularly when accompanied by persistent foot, ankle, knee or hip pain, can be worth showing to a podiatrist or foot-and-ankle specialist.

The shape matters too. A narrow toe box can crowd the toes, while a shoe that is too loose allows the foot

to slide around inside it. Footwear should also be chosen for the activity: the shoe that is comfortable for an office day may not be appropriate for a long walk.

How well do your feet move?

These simple movements can be tried while seated in a sturdy chair, which removes the risk of losing balance.

Take off your shoes and keep both feet flat on the floor. Try lifting all five toes while keeping your heels and the balls of your feet down. Next, see whether you can lower the four smaller toes while keeping the big toe raised. Then reverse it: keep the big toe down while lifting the other four.

Many people find this surprisingly difficult. It is not a diagnostic test and there is no pass or fail; it simply asks the small muscles of the foot to perform movements we rarely consciously demand of them.

Another useful exercise is the "short foot". While seated, keep the heel and toes on the floor and gently draw the ball of the big toe towards the heel. The arch should rise slightly without the toes curling. Hold briefly, release and repeat.

Research suggests exercises of this kind can improve intrinsic foot-muscle strength.

Calf raises can also strengthen an important part of the walking chain. Older adults, anyone with poor balance, or anyone who feels unsteady should do these only while holding

a stable kitchen counter or other fixed support, rather than a movable chair. Rise gently onto the balls of both feet and lower slowly. There is no reason to progress to a single-leg

version without professional guidance if balance is a concern. Stop any exercise that causes pain, dizziness or a feeling of instability.

Is barefoot better?

For a healthy adult without foot problems, spending some time barefoot at home may allow the toes and foot muscles to move differently from the way they do inside structured footwear. That is very different from deciding suddenly to walk or run long distances barefoot. The body adapts to the loads habitually placed upon it. Changing abruptly from cushioned footwear to barefoot or minimalist walking can alter where those forces are absorbed, placing greater demands on the foot, ankle, calf and Achilles tendon. Anyone interested in making the transition should therefore increase the time gradually rather than treating barefoot walking as a fitness challenge. Some people should be particularly cautious. Diabetes can cause peripheral neuropathy, reducing sensation in the feet, so a cut, blister or burn may not immediately be noticed. People with significant foot deformities, balance difficulties, previous stress fractures, osteoporosis or an existing foot or ankle injury should seek professional advice before substantially changing their footwear or activity. Nor does barefoot automatically mean better.

A person who walks comfortably and without pain in conventional shoes does not need to change simply because minimalist footwear has become fashionable. Mahatma Gandhi's long walks belonged to a very different time and purpose, and his physical endurance remains one of the striking aspects of his public life. You may not walk quite as much, but your feet still deserve attention: keeping them healthy requires the right footwear, strength, mobility and regular use throughout life.

The writer is an orthopaedic surgeon, superspecialist in foot and ankle and sports medicine, Mumbai Knee Foot Ankle Clinic



Dr Pradeep Moonot



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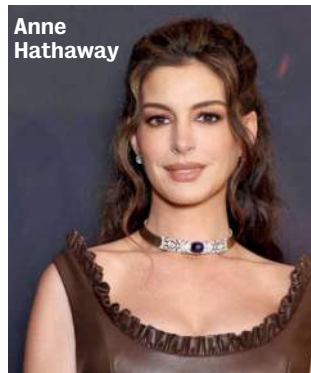
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Anne on navigating pregnancy during TDWP2

Anne Hathaway opened up about her pregnancy symptoms: she developed such an intense sense of smell that she felt she could smell time, she said. Hathaway, who was pregnant during the promotional tour for *The Devil Wears Prada 2*, said as much on *The Tonight Show* starring Jimmy Fallon. The actress said she found out she was pregnant two-and-a-half weeks before TDWP2 press tour kicked off. And I was just like, how is that going to work?" she recalled. "You know, my main symptom during my first pregnancy was fatigue, and that didn't happen this time. This time, my main symptom was, well, acne. But I had, like, the craziest sense of smell," Hathaway said, adding, "The thing about pregnancy smell is you smell time." Explaining, Hathaway said, "So you don't just smell this summer. You smell all of them. A couple other summers. I went back to the 80s."



Anne Hathaway



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05	Master of Management Studies (MMS)	1	1	2
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'The mystery around Mohini drew me towards the film'



Yami Gautam

Yami Gautam says the unpredictability of her character Mohini in the upcoming entertainer Nayyi Navelli is what drew her to the role.

As makers unveiled the trailer on Wednesday, Yami spoke about playing Mohini, saying, "What drew me to Mohini is that she is never quite what you expect. There's a warmth and familiarity to her, but also a mystery that slowly reveals itself."

She further shared, "The film gave me the opportunity to explore a character that moves seamlessly between family, humour, emotion, fantasy and action, while still staying rooted at heart. It was a wonderful experience working with



A still from the film Nayyi Navelli

Balaji sir, Aanand sir, Himanshu, and the entire team. I'm really excited for audiences to meet Mohini this Dussehra and discover her for themselves."

Set in Meerut, the film follows the Awasthi family as the arrival of their seemingly perfect new bahu, Mohini, raises questions. What begins with familiar wedding rituals soon takes an unexpected turn. Director Balaji Mohan said, "What makes 'Nayyi Navelli' special to me

is that it starts with a family that feels instantly relatable, with all the quirks, opinions and madness you'd recognise from any family, and then takes things somewhere completely unexpected that will leave you pleasantly surprised." — IANS

I fulfilled my father's dream through Anupamaa, says Rupali Ganguly

At FICCI Frames 2026, the actress and producer Rajan Shahi reflect on how the show sparked conversations around women's self-worth and independence



Rupali Ganguly and Rajan Shahi

Hasti Doshi
hasti.doshi@timesofindia.com

At the FICCI Frames 2026 session From Screen to Society: Rewriting Women's Stories of Independence, actress Rupali Ganguly and Anupamaa producer Rajan Shahi discussed how mainstream television can go beyond entertainment to influence conversations around women, financial independence and self-worth.

Rajan recalled that Anupamaa came at a time when the television industry was facing considerable uncertainty. "Anupama aired during Covid, when people said TV is over and this medium

just has reruns and old shows playing. The industry had to grow, and a mother's story really worked," he said. He revealed that the character was inspired by his own mother. "I see Anupama's story in my mom and I got inspired to create the show."

For Rajan, the impact of the show has extended far beyond ratings and television screens. "This show started conversations amongst people and women, which is important. Men are also watching the show, which changed their mindset too towards their mothers and wives," he said.

He also credited Rupali with becoming synonymous with the character, while she

credited him for transforming both her career and the way she viewed herself.

Rupali also recalled that her initial concern, when she was offered the role, was her appearance. "Losing weight and looking right was my priority when this show came to me, but we were starting in three days and Rajan said, 'I want you the way you are.' I don't know why I related looking good with being a good actor. I accept myself, and that's what I have learnt from the show," she said.

Rupali also shared, "My dad always dreamt of having a house and felt sad that he didn't leave a house for us. I fulfilled my father's dream of having a house through this show," she said.

Big B starts KBC shoot seated after suffering a knee injury



Amitabh Bachchan

Amitabh Bachchan began the latest episode of Kaun Banega Crorepati 18 seated instead of making his usual standing monologue, revealing that he had injured his knee during the previous day's shoot. "Usually, I do my monologue standing at the centre but today, I have a knee injury," he said.

Explaining what happened, Bachchan added, "Yesterday, during the shoot, I slipped and fell and injured my knee." Pointing to his left knee, the veteran actor reassured the audience that the injury was not serious. He said he would continue to stand while hosting the contestants but had some "little bit of difficulty standing up" and therefore chose to remain seated during the opening monologue. The audience wished him a speedy recovery.

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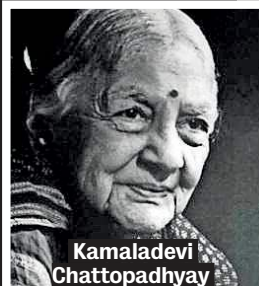
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Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay



Hansa Mehta



Aruna Asaf Ali

The right to roam

Women once marched through Bombay demanding freedom. This Gandhi Jayanti, we examine whether women can navigate this city freely now

Soniya Pondcar
mirrorfeedback@timesofindia.com

Over the past week, women students in Delhi have been protesting after a series of sexual assaults. The Supreme Court, taking suo motu cognisance of recent rape cases in Delhi-NCR, has also turned its attention to women's safety in public spaces, saying these cannot be allowed to become "zones of high risk". This Gandhi Jayanti, we look back at an earlier generation of women for whom claiming public space was part of the fight for freedom. Mirror invites you to walk in their footsteps while you consider the irony: Nearly a century later, the freedom to occupy those same public spaces entirely without fear remains a distant dream for many women.

Start at Girgaum Chowpatty

In April 1930, as Gandhiji walked towards Dandi to challenge the British monopoly on salt, Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay led thousands of women to Chowpatty, where they collected seawater and boiled it on makeshift stoves to make contraband salt. She was 27 at the time and already an experienced political organiser. Educated at Queen Mary's College in Madras and later in London, Chattopadhyay had joined the Congress and the Seva Dal, where she organised and trained women volunteers.

In 1926, she became the first woman in India to contest a legislative seat. In the decades that followed, she would play a major role in establishing institutions devoted to Indian handicrafts, handlooms, theatre and the performing arts. During the Salt Satyagraha, Chattopadhyay packaged contraband salt and took it into Bombay's commercial district to raise money for the movement. One of her most famous stops was the Bombay Stock Exchange, where she sold packets to brokers.



Gowalia Tank



Chowpatty



Azad Maidan

Women once protested here to free India. Yet, today, many still don't feel safe here

Walk into Bhuleshwar

On May 1, Hansa Mehta led members of the Desh Sevika Sangh into Bhuleshwar. They sat outside shops, spun yarn and asked customers not to buy imported goods. The campaign extended to Mulji Jetha Market, then one of Bombay's principal cloth markets. Mehta, 32, had studied philosophy in Baroda before travelling to England, where she studied journalism and sociology. Her participation in the freedom movement led to imprisonment. Her later career was remarkable, too. She served in India's Constituent Assembly and became vice-chancellor of Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda. At the UN, she objected to the phrase "all men are born free and equal" — the final now reads "all human beings are born free and equal".

Stop at Azad Maidan

In October 26, 1930, despite prohibitory orders, Avantikabai Gokhale — born in 1882, married at age nine, and educated with the support of her husband and father-in-law — led women volunteers to Azad Maidan, where they raised the national flag. She was arrested during the Civil Disobedience Movement and was imprisoned for political activity.

Go on to August Kranti Maidan

On August 8, 1942, at Gowalia Tank, now

August Kranti Maidan, Gandhi gave the "Do or Die" call as the Congress launched the Quit India Movement. Before dawn the following morning, Gandhi and most of the senior Congress leadership had been arrested. Aruna Asaf Ali, then 33, went ahead with the meeting and hoisted the Congress flag at Gowalia Tank on August 9.

Though she was arrested on other occasions, after Gowalia Tank, Ali evaded arrest and continued working underground. The colonial authorities confiscated and sold her property and announced a reward for information leading to her capture. She remained underground until 1946. After Independence, she continued in politics and publishing and, in 1958, became Delhi's first woman mayor.

Finish near Chowpatty

Usha Mehta was 22 and studying law when the Quit India Movement began. She left her studies and joined a small group that set up an underground radio station in Bombay. As the broadcasts carried news about the movement, the transmitter could not remain in one place for long. The group moved between addresses in Laburnum Road, Sandhurst Road, Girgaum and near Mahalakshmi as the police tried

Jyoti Kambli, 50, Thane, comms trainer

Mumbai and Thane feel comparatively safer than UP, MP and Delhi, but women still cannot freely travel at night. Internal roads, service roads often lack streetlights and police. Public toilets at night are difficult to find and can feel unsafe.



Jasmin Thakar, 22, Borivali, theatre production and research lead

Mumbai is safer than some other Indian cities, but one isn't always comfortable enough to wear what one ways. It feels more unsafe at night, and festivals where men seem drunk.

Mallika Lokhande, 26, Santa Cruz, actor

Mumbai is safer than Delhi and Vadodara, but crowded spaces require us to stay alert. A local train murder has me worried. I feel women must stay cautious today.



to trace the signal. In November, the station was discovered and Mehta was arrested. She spent several years in prison.

After Independence, she returned to university, completed a doctorate on Gandhi's political and social thought and taught political science at the University of Bombay.

When you walk this route, here's something to think about: Can India call itself truly free while women still calculate which road to take, when to leave and whether they will make it home safely?

05 THINGS TO DO TODAY



Bake your own pizza

Knead fresh dough, make a sauce from tomatoes, herbs and aromatics, then assemble your own pizza with vegetarian or non-vegetarian toppings. Add hot honey, herb oils or fresh garnishes, and finish with a sweet dessert pizza.

📍 **WHERE:** Wholesome Studio, Bandra (W)

🕒 **WHEN:** 6 PM

🎫 **ENTRY:** ₹3,199 onwards

📖 **BOOK:** @imwholesome.india

Remember the mother

Watch Traasadi, a Hindi solo drama about a young boy who faces life after his mother's death. The play draws from their everyday conversations and memories, with moments of humour and relatability.

📍 **WHERE:** Funkaar Studio, Andheri (W)

🕒 **WHEN:** 7.15 PM

🎫 **ENTRY:** ₹99

📞 **CALL:** 9322279896

Master a Brazilian art

Turn fabric scraps into rounded flowers at this Brazilian Fuxico workshop. Fold, gather and stitch small pieces of cloth into decorative blooms, then take home your creations to brighten a corner of your home.

📍 **WHERE:** Hitchki NESCO, Goregaon (W)

🕒 **WHEN:** 2.30 PM

🎫 **ENTRY:** ₹1,199

📖 **BOOK:** smallworld.co



Test your mettle

Take on ROAR Games, India's hybrid fitness race, with runs and strength challenges inspired by traditional movements such as Dands, Baithaks and Parikrama. Choose from four race formats, from 2.5km to 10km, and test your strength, speed and endurance.

📍 **WHERE:** Wings Sports Centre, Bandra (W)

🕒 **WHEN:** 5 AM onwards

🎫 **ENTRY:** Registration required

📖 **BOOK:** theroargames.com



Sing your heart out

Start your weekend by belting it out to your favourite songs at Goated Karaoke Nights, where you can grab the mic, sing along to popular hits and enjoy a night of music with friends.

📍 **WHERE:** Goat Brew, Andheri (W)

🕒 **WHEN:** 9 PM onwards

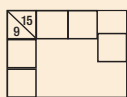
🎫 **ENTRY:** ₹500 onwards

📞 **CALL:** 9650913741



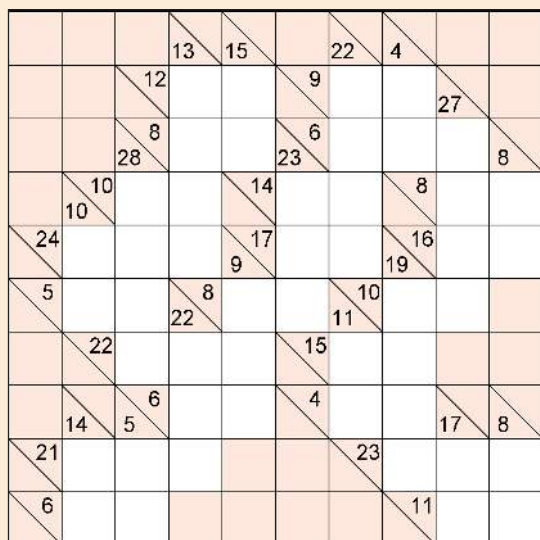
KAKURO

The numbers in the grey squares refer to the sums of the digits that you must fill into the empty spaces directly below or to the right of the grey square containing the number. For instance, in the given example, the 3 boxes horizontally next to 15 must contain 3 digits that add up to 15, whereas for 9, it



is the 2 boxes placed vertically under it that must add up to 9. No zeros are used here, only the digits 1 through 9.

Note: A digit cannot appear more than once in any particular digit combination. For instance, in the example, we cannot have the combination of 4+7+4 for 15.



GOFIGURE

Place the four numbers in the first, third, fifth, and seventh boxes and whatever operators you care to use in the second, fourth, and sixth boxes in the correct order to get the answer. Use the numbers only once.

Easy

$$\boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} = 2$$

Medium

$$\boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} = 22$$

Hard

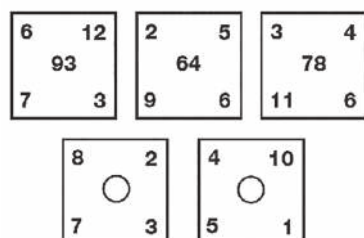
$$\boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} \boxed{} = 41$$

The operators



MENSA PUZZLE

Which numbers need to be placed in the circles in the bottom two boxes?



SOLUTION
In each square the central value equals the product of the top two numbers and the product of the bottom two numbers.
37 & 45

WORDSEARCH

Bookstore

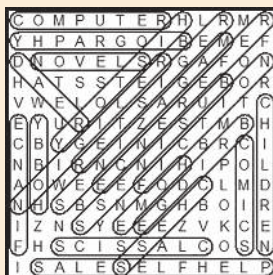
Can you find the words connected in one way or the other with the theme indicated by the title in today's Word Search?

The words may be read horizontally, vertically or diagonally either forwards or backwards, but always in straight lines. Use a ruler to cross them through as you find them.



Wordlist:

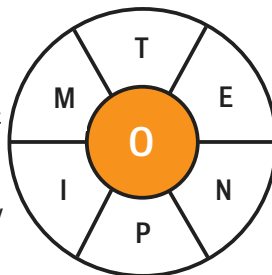
- Biography
- Bridge
- Business
- Chess
- Children
- Classics
- Comics
- Computer
- Fiction
- Finance
- History
- Hobby
- Home
- Magazines
- Novels
- Read
- Reference
- Register
- Religion
- Sales
- Self Help



BULL'S EYE

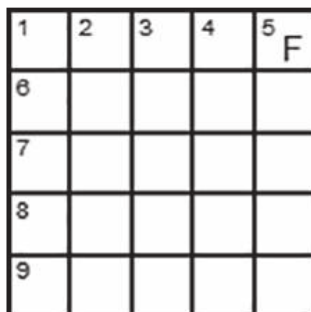
How many words of four or more letters can you make from the letters shown? Every word must contain the central letter. There should be one seven-letter word. British English Dictionary is used as a reference.

- 15 Average 16 Good
- 18 Outstanding



FAST FIVE

How long do you think it will take you to unscramble the 10 words shown below and fit them correctly into the grid in the order given? One letter has already been entered to get you started. On your marks, get set...



Across

- 1 Faced
- 6 Do ere
- 7 Far me
- 8 Too id
- 9 Rings

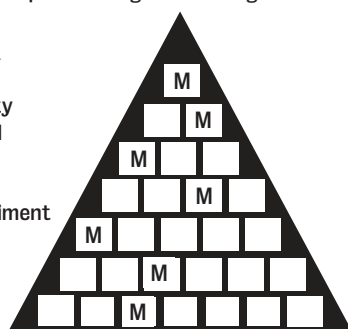
Down

- 1 Go fed
- 2 Or err
- 3 To CIA
- 4 A mind
- 5 D Fees

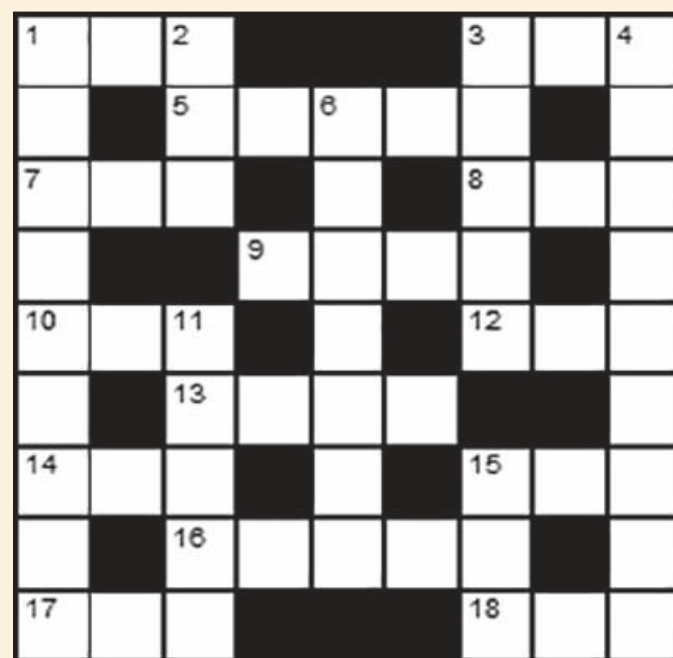
ALPHA TRIANGLE

Beginning at the top move towards the bottom seven-letter word by adding a letter at each step and rearranging. A correct and different word must be made at each step answering to the clue given.

- 1 Bond's boss
- 2 Sacred mantra
- 3 A Stodge
- 4 Seven-hilled city
- 5 Time-honoured customs
- 6 Abalone shells
- 7 Penitent's sentiment



MUMBAI MINI CROSSWORD



Across

- 1 Harry Potter's best friend (3)
- 3 Maritime letters (3)
- 5 Factions (5)
- 7 BKC's ___ World Drive (3)
- 8 International Standard Atmosphere (3)
- 9 Cricket commentator Lal (4)
- 10 Hum and ___ : hesitate ? (3)
- 12 Gujarat's Sasan ___ (3)
- 13 Central parts of wheels (4)
- 14 Contend with (3)
- 15 Tata Administrative

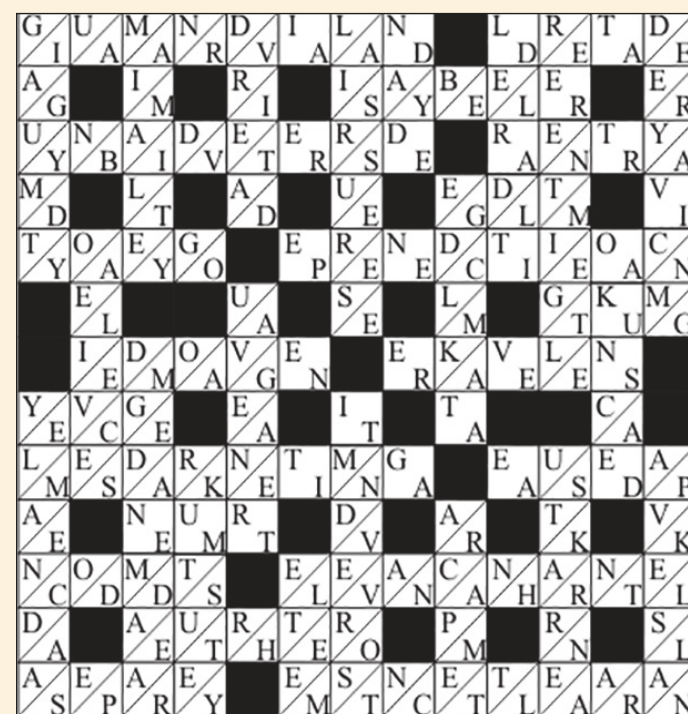
Services, acronym (3)

- 16 Invalidate (5)
- 17 Nothing at all (3)
- 18 US spy bureau (3)

Down

- 1 Governor's residence (3,6)
- 2 Cpl. or sgt. (3)
- 3 Employing (5)
- 4 It used to be called Jacob Circle (4,5)
- 6 ___ Road : Ballard Estate area, honouring a playwright (7)
- 11 Mosquito bite (5)
- 15 Gentle handling, initially (3)

STRIKEOUT



This crossword has no clues and the answer is there waiting for you. All you have to do is find it in each square. You have a choice of two letters, one of which you must strike out. If you choose correctly, you will be left with a grid that contains real words.

RIDDLER

Which of these is not a position in a netball team:

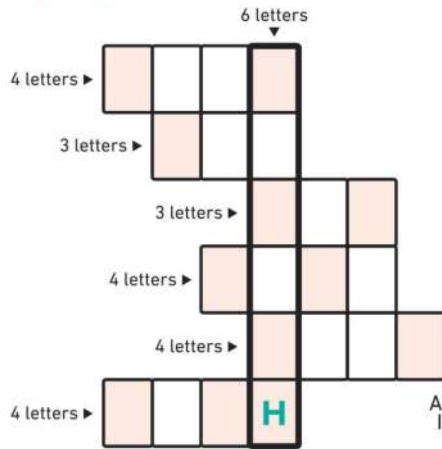
Shooting Guard; Wing Attack; Centre; Goal Defence; or Goal Shooter?



CROSSOKU

by WordIt!

#0475

A⁵ I⁵ V⁴ S⁴ L³ H¹

□ VOWEL □ CONSONANT

Play like crossword. Solve like sudoku.
Form 7 words using the letters
above in the grid. Each letter's count
is marked beside it. Vowels go only in
the white boxes. No row or column
should repeat a letter.

Time yourself: 2 mins 4 mins 6 mins

Excellent Great Good



SUDOKUCHALLENGE

	8	7	1		6			2
		2	3	8	7			
	4		5					
		1			3	6	4	
2	5	4				9		
					1		7	
			8	6	2	4		
4			7		3	6	9	

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from one to nine must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

HIDATO

			11		
			10		14
		6	21	17	15
1					
25			3		

SUM SUDOKU

22	12		16		8		3	
		3	12	14	6		11	15
15					22	10		
	8		9				13	
6	9					13	12	
	13	11		8	12			8
		7				13	15	
12		30						
10		8			6		13	

QUICKCROSSWORD

	1		2		3		4		5		6	
7							8					
9					10							
11	12							13				
							14					
15			16			17			18			
					19							
20									21		22	
23							24					

ACROSS

- 7 A white cotton cloth (6)
8 Ex-India southpaw Vinod ____ (6)
9 "Need" anagram for a small valley (4)
10 Searching for food or fodder (8)
11 One who gives up (7)
13 On the move (5)
15 Guwahati locale (5)
17 Study of animals (7)
20 German physicist, Albert ____ (8)
21 Idi Amin's title (4)
23 Expurgate - being a fault-finder? (6)
24 Sowed a field (6)

DOWN

- 1 Novelist ____ Austen (4)
2 Broadest (6)
3 Hard candies (7)
4 Woman's garment (5)
5 Spanish friends (6)
6 Making unable to see, robbing of judgment (8)
12 Clean, unsullied; in mint condition (8)
14 Person or thing just not specified (2-3-2)
16 Estimate value (6)
18 Provided with temporary accommodation (6)
19 Legatees (5)
22 Hue changer (4)

SOLUTIONS

N	I	L										
A	A	N	N	U	L							
V	I	E	A		T	A	S					
A		H	U	B	S		A					
G	I	R		Z		W						
A	R	U	N									
J	I	O		A								
A		C	A	M	P	S						
R	O	N										

MUMBAI MINI CROSSWORD

6	5	1										
21	9	4	8									
14	5	6	5	1								
22	7	9	6	7								
4	1	4	2	2	6							
9	8	7	9	8	8							
10	9	1	5	9	5							
23	2	6	2	2	1	3						
12	3	9	3	9	6	3						
13	15											

KAKURO

D	S	S	D	S	S	D	S	S	D	S	S	D
C	E	N	S	O	R	S	E	D	E	D	E	D
L	E	I	D	G								
E	I	N	S	T	E	I	N	D	A	D	A	
O	A	H	S	O								
A	S	S	A	M	Z	O	L	O	G	Y		
N	S	S										
Q	U	I	T	T	E	R	A	S	T	I	R	
D	E	N	E	F	O	R	A	G	I	N	G	
N	D	F	I	I								
C	A	L	I	C	O							
J	W	T	S	A	B							

QUICK CROSSWORD

4	2	8	7	5	3	6	9	1
7	1	9	8	6	2	4	5	3
6	3	5	4	9	1	2	7	8
2	5	4	6	3	8	9	1	7
3	7	6	9	1	4	8	2	5
8	9	1	2	7	5	3	6	4
1	4	3	5	2	9	7	8	6
5	6	2	3	8	7	1	4	9
9	8	7	1	4	6	5	3	2

SUDOKU

S	P	R	Y	E	T	C	E	R	A
D	E	T	H	E	R	M	A	R	L
N	O	D	S	L	E	A	C	H	A
A	N	U	T	V	A	T	K		
L	E	A	R	N	I	N	G	A	S
E	V	E	E	I	T	C			
I	M	A	G	E	R	A	V	E	N
L	A	E	L	T	U	G			
Y	O	Y	O	E	R	E	C	T	I
D	U	N	I	T	D	U	E	L	M
A	M	I	S	A	B	E	R	R	
G	A	R	D	I	A	N	D	E	A

STRIKE OUT

25	2	3	4	19
1	24	5	20	18
23	6	21	17	15
7	22	10	16	14
8	9	11	12	13

HIDATO

1	9	3	5	8	2	4	6	7
8	4	7	9	6	3	1	5	2
5	2	6	1	7	4	9	8	3
4	6	9	2	1	8	7	3	5
2	1	8	3	5	7	6	9	4
7	3	5	6	4	9	2	1	8
3	5	1	4	2	6	8	7	9
9	7	2	8	3	1	5	4	6
6	8	4	7	9	5	3	2	1

SUM SUDOKU

D	E	C	A	F
E	R	O	D	E
F	R	A	M	E
O	O	T	I	D
G	R	I	N	S

FAST FIVE

BULL'S EYE
into, mope, mote, note, omen,
omit, open, opine, poen, PIMENTO,
pinto, poem, poet, point, tempo,
tome, tone, tope

ALPHA TRIANGLE

RIDDLER
(basketball)
Shooting Guard

GO FIGURE

Easy
3 + 4 + 3 - 8 = 2
Medium
6 × 4 + 4 - 6 = 22
Hard
4 × 7 + 4 + 9 = 41

M, Om, Moe, Rome, Mores,
Ormers, Remorse.

comics | DOONESBURY BY GARRY TRUDEAU



CUL DE SAC BY RICHARD THOMPSON



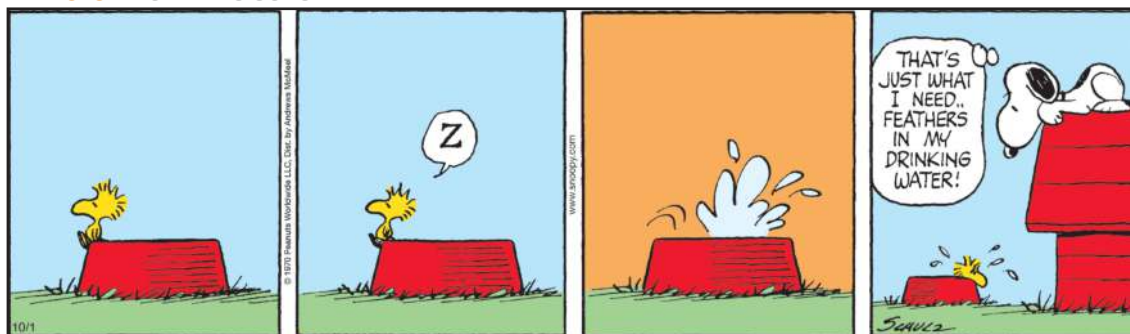
BETTY BY GARY DELAINEY AND GERRY RASMUSSEN



PEARLS BEFORE SWINE BY STEPHANS PASTIS



PEANUTS BY CHARLES SCHULZ

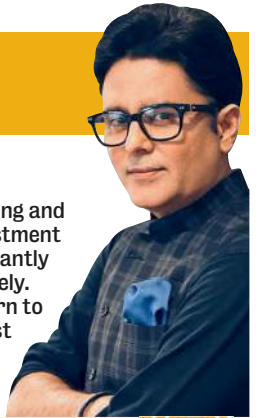


SHIVA AND SATI BY GAYATRI MADAN DUTT



WRITTEN IN THE STARS

DR SUNDEEP KOCHAR



If it's your birthday today

This birthday begins a year of financial restructuring and greater independence. A new income stream, investment decision or change in spending habits could significantly alter your sense of security. Avoid lending impulsively. Personal relationships become steadier as you learn to communicate practical expectations. The strongest gains will come from choices that prioritise long-term freedom over immediate rewards.

CAPRICORN

You could be handed responsibilities beyond your position. Treat this seriously, but establish priorities before accepting them. This may be an opportunity to demonstrate readiness for greater influence.



CANCER

You may realise that love requires something different from what you previously expected. Be honest about your emotional needs rather than adjusting yourself endlessly to keep another person comfortable.



AQUARIUS

A niche interest could introduce you to someone fascinating. Whether through a community, event or online space, stay curious; an unusual connection may become one of the more memorable encounters this month.



LEO

Someone close could make a romantic gesture that reminds you how valued you are. Allow yourself to enjoy the attention without analysing it; appreciation received freely can strengthen your confidence.



PISCES

A creative idea may emerge from a dream, image or fleeting thought. Write it down immediately and give it structure later. What feels abstract now could become the beginning of something tangible.



VIRGO

An overlooked area of your life may benefit from some organisation. Choose one drawer, schedule, digital folder or unfinished task rather than tackling everything, and let visible progress motivate you further.



ARIES

An old friend may reappear with a conversation that feels surprisingly natural. Reconnecting could remind you how much you've changed while revealing that some bonds remain meaningful despite long periods apart.



LIBRA

A romantic choice may require greater honesty than diplomacy. Instead of saying what keeps everyone comfortable, acknowledge what you genuinely want. Clarity may feel uncomfortable initially but prevents confusion later.



TAURUS

Your home may need one small improvement that you've been postponing. Fixing or rearranging something can make your surroundings feel considerably more comfortable.



SCORPIO

Someone's behaviour may reveal more than their words have. Watch what they consistently do rather than focusing on promises or impressions.



GEMINI

A casual conversation could turn into a promising professional exchange. Someone you meet informally may mention an opening, project or introduction worth pursuing.



SAGITTARIUS

A professional possibility connected to another city could appear unexpectedly. Research the practicalities before getting excited, especially relocation, travel and timing. An unfamiliar environment may offer room for growth.


www.sundeepkochar.com



If I have to be absolutely honest, there has to be a bit more of a contest between bat and ball but this is not cricket, this is only batting."

-Gautam Gambhir after India chased down 400-plus against WI

Friday, October 2, 2026

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PICS: REUTERS & AP



SAILING THROUGH: Prince Kurisinkal Noble (L) and Manu Francis won a silver in men's skiff event

SILVER SPLASH

Cousins Prince, Manu finish runners-up in sailing, Nitesh comes second in greco-roman wrestling; cricket and hockey teams to fight for gold

#NAGOYA

Rare silver medals in skiff sailing and greco-roman wrestling were the highlights for India, while the country's men's teams in cricket and hockey moved into their respective finals with contrasting performances in pursuit of a golden finish at the Asian Games on Thursday.

India's overall medal haul rose to 65, including 10 gold, 23 silver and 32 bronze medals, keeping the country inside the top 10 of the standings.

Kerala cousins Prince Kurisinkal Noble and Manu Francis gave the Indian contingent an early reason to celebrate with a silver-winning effort in the men's skiff competition, finishing behind China and ahead of Hong Kong, China after winning one and finishing second in three of the nine races in the regatta. It was India's first sailing medal of the ongoing edition.

The Indian team of Harshita Tomar and Shital Verma claimed the women's bronze in the same event. In the second half of the day, Nitesh Siwach (97kg) lost his final 4-0 to Japan's Yuri Nakazato to settle for a silver, a rarity for India in greco-roman wrestling.

In between, both the men's and women's squash teams signed off with bronze medals after losing their semifinal clashes, while compound archer Ganesh Mani Ratnam Thirumuru also added a bronze to the tally.

Anahat Singh, Joshana Chinappa, Tanvi Khanna and Shameena Riaz were the first to bow out after losing 1-2 to Hong Kong.

Singles silver medallist Anahat was expected to steer India through but squandered four match points before going down 11-9, 11-8, 6-11, 11-13, 10-12 to world No. 25 Sin Yuk Chan in the opener.

World No. 73 Tanvi then scripted a fine comeback with a 3-1 (4-11, 13-11, 11-9, 13-11) win over world No. 40 Ka Yi Lee to keep India's hopes alive in the three-match contest. However, veteran Joshana Chinappa, a former world top-10 player, suffered a straight-games defeat to world No. 39 Ho Tze Lok.

Later, the defending champion men's squad of Abhay Singh, Velavan Senthilkumar, Veer Chotrani



TOUGH LUCK: Nitesh Siwach lost to Yuri Nakazato in greco-roman 97kg category

and Suraj Chand were beaten 1-2 by Malaysia to settle for a third-place finish.

Compound archer Thirumuru also added bronze to the tally by making a comeback to win his men's individual bronze-medal playoff with a commanding performance. Thirumuru, who was part of the gold-winning men's team on Wednesday, defeated Vietnam's Cong Duc Dang 149-144. It was near-perfect shooting from the 20-year-old Indian, who found the mark with 14 of his 15 shots in the playoff.

Ishan stars for Men in Blue

The Shreyas Iyer-led Indian T20 side was short on both practice and game time heading into its semifinal against Sri Lanka. But that hardly mattered once the action began as India posted a daunting 169/7 on a difficult track before dismissing the Islanders for a record-low 45 to march into the final.

The win was built around a calculated unbeaten 80 off 46 balls from Ishan Kishan and the customary brilliance of Jasprit Bumrah and Axar Patel, who picked up two wickets apiece.

Pakistan await India in the final after beating Bangladesh in the other semifinal, and discussion is now expected to intensify over the possibility, or lack thereof, of a handshake between the players.

India in hockey final

Defending champions India survived a massive scare from Pakistan in the semifinal before Abhishek struck with just 45 seconds remaining to seal a dramatic 4-3 victory and book the side's place in the men's hockey final.

Harmanpreet Singh converted two perfectly executed penalty corners in the fifth and 13th minutes, while Sukhjeet Singh scored a field goal in the 23rd minute. Abhishek netted the winner from open play in the final minute. Pakistan's goals came through Abu Mahmood (30th minute), Hannan Shahid (45th) and Waheed Rana (49th).

The defending champions looked set for a comfortable win after Harmanpreet's brace and Sukhjeet's strike put them firmly in control.

But a stunning second-half collapse allowed Pakistan to claw their way back, scoring three goals to push India to the brink of an embarrassing defeat before Abhishek's late strike rescued the contest.

Golfers in sight of medals

The unstoppable Pranavi Urs fired a blistering seven-under 63 in the second round of the golf competition to move within two strokes of leader Shannon Tan (64) of Singapore and occupy sole second place.

Her charge also transformed the women's team competition, lifting India into bronze-medal position at seven-under-par 273. Diksha Dagar (71-73) was tied 21st, while Aditi Ashok (71-74) was tied 25th. The two best scores in each round count towards the team standings.

Medal confirmed in sepaktakraw

India advanced to the men's quadrant competition semifinals with a 2-1 win over Myanmar, maintaining an unbeaten run and topping Group A to assure themselves of at least a bronze medal.

India beat Myanmar 10-15, 15-13, 15-7 after having defeated Laos and Vietnam in their first two matches. Earlier in the day, they defeated Vietnam 2-0 (15-12, 15-9). Indonesia topped Group B. The semifinals will be held on Friday.

Antonelli eyes Sepang as proving ground for 2026 cars in the wet

SEPANG, MALAYSIA

Mercedes driver **Kimi Antonelli** said Sepang's notorious abrasive surface could prove a welcome surprise should Formula One finally get its first wet race of the season in Malaysia.



The young Italian, who has enjoyed a charmed run of dry conditions throughout his title charge, reckons the Malaysian circuit's rough tarmac would make it the ideal venue to test the sport's 2026 cars in challenging weather.

Thunderstorms are far from unusual in Malaysia, where the tropical climate regularly produces heavy afternoon showers and lightning storms.

"I think this track will be quite OK in the wet...The surface is so open, there's actually not a lot of standing water unless it pours down," Antonelli told reporters, adding that it was the "roughest track tarmac" he had ever seen.

"But if it rains normally, then it would probably be the best track to try these cars for the first time in the rain because the tarmac is so open that the water just doesn't sit on top of the surface. It actually goes in between the stones. So it makes less risk of aquaplaning."

Tyre supplier Pirelli has warned teams to brace for punishing conditions, describing Sepang's surface as "relatively abrasive" with roughness comparable to Bahrain.

But while Antonelli sees opportunity in adversity, his championship rival and teammate George Russell—who trails by 66 points in second—is concerned about the circuit's heat-generating properties should the rain stay away.

"The big difference on this circuit compared to other so-called 'yo-yo' circuits is the tyre overheating," Russell said, contrasting Sepang with tracks like Melbourne, Silverstone, Monza and Canada where surface temperatures are more forgiving.

"Here, surface overheating is going to be a huge thing. You'll be overheating the tyres even on the out-lap of a qualifying session. That may make it more challenging to follow closer and to re-attack."

Reuters

Vengsarkar Academy to conduct selection trials

Dilip Vengsarkar Cricket Academy will conduct selection trials for under-12, under-14 and under-16 at their centres at Oval Maidan, Churchgate, and Mahul. At Oval, the trials will be held on October 6 and 7 from 3pm to 6pm while at Mahul it will be held on October 8 and 9 at same time.

PTI

MMB